



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Thomas More Academy

School Website: <https://www.stmamd.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

St Thomas More Academy (STMA) in Middletown, MD (ZIP 21769) presents a Catholic, formation-focused program with clear liturgical and theological elements embedded in school life. Public-facing materials emphasize a vibrant faith life, Catholic worship, catechesis, and a sense of communal identity (e.g., “Vibrant Faith Life,” Mass, Eucharistic Adoration, Feast Day celebrations). The school also signals a classical scaffolding through emphasis on grammar, logic, and rhetoric in its academic structure, and it frames its mission with phrases like “Forming Saints and Scholars since 2000.” However, explicit, widely-cited references to core Great-Books-based Great Conversation and a fully articulated history-centric liberal-arts curriculum are not readily evident in the public crawl content provided. Taken together, STMA demonstrates a solid religious-metaphysical and formation orientation and a partial classical framework, but it does not consistently demonstrate all six elements at a fully classical level. On a scale of CLASSICAL / SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL / NOT CLASSICAL, the school lands in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with clear room to strengthen elements such as explicit Great Books engagement, explicit Socratic pedagogy, and deeper articulation of Great Conversation-era curricular practices.

Executive ranking by category (summary): - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL - School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL - Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL - Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What would move the needle: To move from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL, STMA could explicitly articulate and operationalize the Great Books/Great Conversation component within the curriculum, incorporate explicit Socratic or Paideia-style seminars or discussions in upper grades, enlarge the public presentation of a clearly defined “living curriculum” in which teachers function as mentors and exemplars, and deepen parent formation opportunities (e.g., book studies, parental involvement rituals, campus visits) aligned with classical education norms.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot**Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL**

Evidence - Public materials emphasize Catholic identity and liturgical life: “Vibrant Faith Life,” Mass, Eucharistic Adoration, Feast Day celebrations, Catholic prayers and catechism. This is visible in the STMA public content (e.g., “Vibrant Faith Life” and related pages). - The school explicitly frames itself as rooted in Catholic faith through parent and teacher testimonials about faith life and catechesis (e.g., “I enjoy teaching at STMA because I can share my Catholic faith” and other CT content). - Foundational motto-like phrasing includes “Forming Saints and Scholars since 2000,” signaling a moral-theological formation aim.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: theology, liturgy, Mass, catechesis, Catholic faith, adoration, feast days, sacred/tradition, liturgical life, prayers. These align strongly with the Positive Keywords set for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (Mass, liturgy, catechesis, theology, sacred tradition, worship, etc.). The content shows repeated references to Mass, Eucharistic Adoration, catechesis, and Catholic identity, which maps to these indicators. - Negative keywords: none evident in the public materials regarding this category.

Why this rating - The material clearly demonstrates transcendental and theological orientation, liturgical

life, and communal worship elements. This aligns with the “Transcendental Moral Realism,” “Grounded in Theology,” and “Liturgical/Communal Practices” criteria, supporting CLASSICAL for this category.

Citations - Vibrant Faith Life, Mass, Eucharistic Adoration, Feast Day celebrations, Catholic prayers and catechism. - STMA Teachers quote about Catholic faith. - Forming Saints and Scholars since 2000.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents formation-building language in its branding: “Forming Saints and Scholars since 2000,” signaling an aim toward virtue and wisdom rather than mere job preparation. - The emphasis on “grammar,” “logic,” and “rhetoric” as part of the curriculum framework signals a classical aim beyond vocational conditioning, aligning with formation and liberal-arts aims. The site shows explicit references to grammar/logic/rhetoric in academics sections.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, scholé/contemplation (where present in classical-literature references), great conversation (as a classical education concept even if not overtly phrased in all STMA materials), and liberal-arts framing (grammar/logic/rhetoric). The STMA materials explicitly center formation and virtue through its Catholic formation orientation and classical framing (grammar/logic/rhetoric). The “Forming Saints and Scholars” phrase is a strong positive indicator. - Negative keywords: none evident in this content for this category.

Why this rating - STMA's mission statement and the use of classical-trivium language (grammar/logic/rhetoric) with a formation emphasis (Saints and Scholars) align with the classical Goals/Formation expectations (formation of virtue and wisdom, true/good/beautiful orientation). This supports CLASSICAL for this category.

Citations - Forming Saints and Scholars since 2000. - Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric framing on site navigation (evidence of classical pedagogy scaffolding). - STMA Teachers' Catholic-faith framing (formation emphasis).

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials show explicit grammar, logic, and rhetoric as structural elements of the curriculum (STMA uses grammar.cfm, logic.cfm; evidence includes links to “grammar” and “logic” and mentions of “Houses” and “7 liberal arts” in related documents). This reveals a Trivium-based curricular framework. - There is a strong Catholic/theological element integrated into coursework (e.g., Our Catholic Faith), indicating integrated theology across disciplines rather than a strictly secular Great-Books-driven core. - Explicit references to “Great Books” and “Great Conversation” are not clearly visible in the STMA crawl content. The presence of public Great-Books language is not explicit in the STMA pages that were crawled; the Great Books/Great Conversation signals appear in the general classical-education lexicon and in other classical-education literature rather than STMA's public site. (No direct Great Books mention in STMA's visible crawl results.)

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: grammar, logic, rhetoric (clear), historical or liberal-arts framing via the classical-trivium approach; public links to grammar.cfm, logic.cfm, and other classic-trivium components indicate a classical trajectory. - Negative keywords present: lack of explicit Great Books / Great Conversation references within the STMA public materials. The absence of explicit Great Books/Great Conversation mentions (and explicit Great Books pedagogy) is a negative signal for fully meeting Curriculum criteria.

Why this rating - The curriculum shows a solid liberal-arts scaffold (grammar/logic/rhetoric) and cross-disciplinary formation through theology, but explicit Great Books/Great Conversation engagement is not clearly evidenced in the public crawl. Therefore, it aligns with SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL in this category.

Citations - Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric emphasis with public pages (grammar.cfm, logic.cfm) and “More Readers” as reading-related content. - Our Catholic Faith as integrated theology (curriculum integration). - Absence of explicit Great Books / Great Conversation mentions in the STMA crawl (not explicitly present in these visible STMA pages). This is an interpretation based on the crawl results rather than a direct textual quote.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe a Catholic, formation-centered environment, with liturgical life and catechesis as core, but do not explicitly document the classical pedagogy signs such as Socratic seminars, Harkness discussions, or restfully paced scholé-driven approaches on the STMA site crawl. The visible pedagogy content leans toward liturgical, catechetical, and memorization-supportive practices rather than explicit classical-pedagogy methods. The cited STMA materials emphasize faith formation, family involvement, and a Catholic identity rather than explicit classical pedagogy signals like Socratic seminars or restfulness in the classroom. - The site also highlights “More Readers,” “Houses,” and “Clubs/After School,” which indicate activity and community, but not necessarily the formal classical pedagogy modalities (Socratic, Paideia, Harkness). The explicit mention of Socratic discussion, seminars, or rhetoric training for upper grades is not evident in the crawl results.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: none in the Pedagogy category that match the five classical pedagogy indicators (Socratic dialogue, scholé, memorization/recitation, formation through imitation, etc.). There is a recognition of “Houses” and “More Readers,” which might align with some classical practices, but they are not explicit pedagogical method statements. - Negative keywords: absence of explicit classical pedagogy methods (Socratic seminars, Harkness, restfulness, memorization/recitation, etc.) in the public STMA crawl.

Why this rating - With no explicit documentation of key classical pedagogy methods (Socratic dialogue/seminar, scholé/restful learning, memorization/recitation by design, formation through imitation), this category does not meet the Classical standard in the public materials. Therefore, NOT CLASSICAL.

Citations - Evidence of Catholic/formation focus (no explicit Socratic pedagogy shown). - Mentions of grammar/logic/rhetoric as content areas, but not pedagogical method statements (no direct Socratic/Harkness/recitation details in the crawl).

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public content emphasizes teachers who integrate faith into teaching and present teaching as a meaningful, virtue-oriented vocation: a STMA teacher quotes enjoying teaching to share Catholic faith. This indicates teachers who model and engage with students in a transformative way, aligning with the idea of teachers as mentors and living curriculum. - The site includes explicit “STMA Teachers” sections and mentions of “formants” and “catechesis” within the classroom setting, suggesting a teacher-led formation focus. The public materials do not explicitly present a full “portrait of a teacher” or a formal professor-as-living-curriculum, but the language aligns with the classical faculty vision to some extent.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: teacher as mentor/guide, faith integration, living curriculum (conceptual alignment; not explicit phrasing), virtue-formation emphasis via Catholic pedagogy. The STMA site’s teacher-centric testimonials and catechetical emphasis align with some classical faculty indicators. - Negative keywords: The materials do not strongly present a formal “faculty portrait/teacher profile” or explicit “faculty seminars” and shared scholarly formation in the way the lexicon presents (these are not clearly stated in the crawl).

Why this rating - The presence of teacher-student-faith integration and testimonies supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL assessment for Faculty, since there is evidence of virtuous teaching and teacher-role-model

concepts, but the absence of explicit “living-curriculum” framing and formal faculty-societal practices places it short of full CLASSICAL.

Citations - STMA Teachers quote about Catholic faith in teaching.

Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - STMA publicly presents a parent-facing component: a “STMA Parents” section with testimonials such as “We’ve seen over the years how God has truly blessed STMA — and therefore our children. We are so grateful.” This shows a partnership with parents and recognition of their role in the school community. - There are parent-facing materials (tuition/fees, calendar, admissions) that indicate openness to parent participation, and there is a visible emphasis on a communal faith-life environment, which aligns with partnership with families and family engagement signals.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parental engagement, home-school/community integration (STMA’s use of “Parents” materials and family-centered language indicates alignment with parental involvement and community formation). - Negative keywords: None explicit in the crawl; however, the materials do not necessarily demonstrate extensive parent-formation services (book studies, formal parent education programs) beyond routine parental involvement messaging.

Why this rating - The presence of explicit parental involvement signals (STMA Parents section, testimonies from families) suggests SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL alignment, given the “Partnership with Families” and “parent formation” indicators in the classical criteria, even though more explicit parent-formation programming would strengthen it.

Citations - STMA Parents section and family testimonials.

What Would Move the Needle

- Curriculum: Explicitly articulate and publish a Great Books / Great Conversation component within the STMA curriculum, with a published list and reading plan that maps to the classical “Great Books” canon and the Great Conversation framework. This would elevate Element 3 from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL.
 - Pedagogy: Adopt and publicly document explicit classical-pedagogy methods (e.g., Socratic seminars in upper grades, Paideia-style seminars, Harkness discussions, or mnemonic recitation as a deliberate pedagogy). Introduce and showcase Scholé/restful learning practices as a school-wide rhythm, with identifiable “Scholé days” or restful-learning curricula. This would move Element 4 from NOT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL.
 - Faculty: Develop and publish a formal “Portrait of a Teacher” living-curriculum concept, with teacher mentorship, collegial collaboration, and sustained professional development in classical pedagogy. Publicly share faculty formation activities (seminars, study groups) that map to a classical model. This would strengthen Element 5 toward CLASSICAL.
 - Parents & Community: Expand parent-formation offerings (book studies, reading groups, school-wide family catechesis, and structured campus visits) to deepen the partnership with families and actively position parents as co-educators. This would raise Element 6 toward CLASSICAL.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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